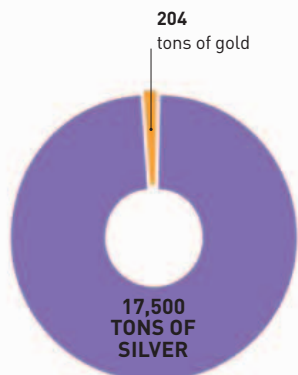




Natives and llamas were pressed into service to transport silver from Potosí, Bolivia. The sprawling shanty town became the largest in the New World.



Gold and silver shipped to Seville

The silver mountain at Potosí meant it dominated the exports of precious metals shipped to Spain from Chile and Mexico from 1503 to 1660.

than the other way around. It took others, notably the Danish astronomer Tycho Brahe in the 1570s, to show by direct observation that Copernicus was right. But a major breach in the geocentric universe theory had been made.

Also published in 1543 was Vesalius's *On the Fabric of the Human Body*. Like Copernicus, **Andreas Vesalius** (1514–64) looked to ancient Greek learning. Unlike Copernicus, he made his own direct observations, based on dissections of human bodies. If any moment can be pinpointed as initiating a **scientific revolution** in the West—the belief the world is best understood by empirical observation—it was perhaps this.

Ever since the formation of the Protestant **Schmalkaldic League** in 1531, Charles V had been forced to skirt its threat to his authority as

Holy Roman Emperor. Persistently distracted by the French and the Ottomans, he had had little option but to appease the league (see 1532) and only in 1546, with France temporarily sidelined after the **Treaty of Crépy** of 1544, did he feel able to confront it directly. The result, decided at the **Battle of Mühlberg** in April 1547, was an overwhelming military success for Charles. The longer-term consequences were mixed.

In 1545, Spanish colonists discovered at **Potosí**, in present-day Bolivia, the biggest single concentration of silver ever found—in effect, an entire mountain of silver. Together with silver found in northern Mexico, it would prove to be the motor of the cash-hungry Spanish Empire, for it was New World silver from Potosí that drove Spanish trade with China just as it financed Spain's attempts at European dominance.

In the same year, at Trent in the Italian Alps, the Catholic Church set out to challenge the Protestant Reformation by reforming and remodeling itself. The **Council of Trent** aimed to eradicate corruption, make the Church's teachings more coherent, and to project itself as a dynamic and competitive religious force. It gave rise to a series of **new Catholic orders** and met twice more, in 1551–52 and 1559–63.

The Portuguese arrive in Japan

Portuguese merchants display some of their wares to the intrigue of the locals on their arrival on Japanese shores in 1543.



- 1542 Renewed hostilities between France and Habsburgs
- January 3, 1543 Death of Juan Rodríguez Cabrilho (born c. 1499)
- 1543 Nicolaus Copernicus (1473–1543) publishes his theory of heliocentricity
- 1543 France attacks the Netherlands, northern Spain, and Nice
- 1543 Portuguese reach Japan
- September 18, 1544 Treaty of Crépy between France and Habsburgs following French victory at Ceresole, north Italy
- April 1545 Spanish discover vast silver deposits at Potosí, Peru
- July 4, 1546 Death of Ottoman admiral Khair ed-Din, better known as Barbarossa (born c. 1478)
- 1546 Portuguese rout Indian army at Diu, India
- 1546 Songhay Empire destroys Mali Empire
- February 20, 1547 Edward VI crowned King of England
- December 2, 1547 Death of Spanish conquistador Hernán Cortés (b. 1485)
- 1547 Mughals take Kabul, in present-day Afghanistan
- September 8, 1548 Death of Catherine Parr (b. 1512)
- 1548 Jesuits launch mission to the Kongo, central Africa
- 1548 Ming government closes China to foreign trade to protect their coast from Japanese pirates
- 1542 Roman Inquisition founded
- July 12, 1543 Henry VIII marries Catherine Parr, his sixth wife
- 1543 Publication of Andreas Vesalius's *On the Fabric of the Human Body*
- 1544 Portuguese trading posts established at Quelimane and Maputo Bay, southern Africa
- 1544 Completion of King's College Chapel, Cambridge
- December 13, 1545 Council of Trent convenes to initiate the Catholic Counter-Reformation (to 1547)
- 1545 Mughals take Kandahar, in present-day Afghanistan
- July 10, 1546 Schmalkaldic War begins between Charles V and the Schmalkaldic League (to 1547)
- January 28, 1547 Death of Henry VIII of England (b. 1491)
- April 24, 1547 Habsburgs defeat the Schmalkaldic League at the Battle of Mühlberg